The passive voice (present and past simple)

Goal: By the end of this lesson, you will be able to form and use the passive voice in the present simple and the past simple to describe landmarks: "The pyramids were built by the ancient Egyptians."

The idea in two lines: In the active voice the subject does the action; in the passive voice the subject receives it. The passive is formed with **be** + **past participle**, and we use it when the result matters more than the doer.

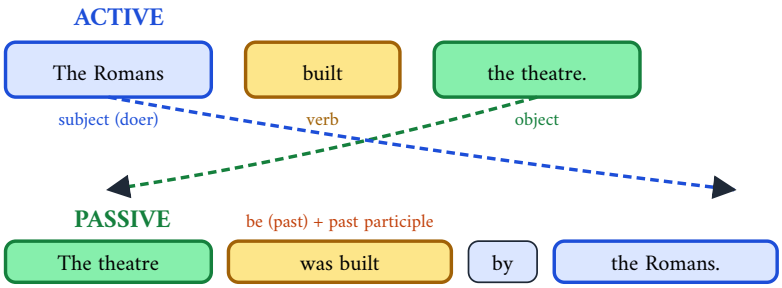


Figure 1: Changing an active sentence into the passive: the object becomes the subject, the verb becomes be + past participle, the doer follows "by".

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Passive voice** = subject + **be** + **past participle** (+ by + agent). The past participle is the third form of the verb: *build – built – built, visit – visited – visited.*
2. **Present simple passive:** *am / is / are* + past participle. *The Casbah is visited by thousands of tourists every year.*
3. **Past simple passive:** *was / were* + past participle. *The Great Wall was built over many centuries.*
4. **Agreement:** *be* agrees with the new subject. *The temple was restored* but *The temples were restored.*
5. The **agent** (by + doer) is often omitted when it is unknown, obvious or unimportant: *The statue was damaged (by someone).*

6. **Negative and question:** *The bridge wasn't finished in 1900. Was it designed by a French engineer?*
7. We use the passive to **focus on the landmark**, not on the people who built it.

🟢 Examples

1. Turn into the passive: *Tourists visit the Colosseum every day.* **Answer:** The Colosseum is visited by tourists every day. **Explanation:** present simple, singular subject, so *is* + *visited*.
2. Turn into the passive: *The Ottomans built Ketchaoua Mosque in the 17th century.* **Answer:** Ketchaoua Mosque was built by the Ottomans in the 17th century. **Explanation:** past simple, so *was* + *built*.
3. Complete: *Many ancient manuscripts … (keep) in the museum.* **Answer:** are kept. **Explanation:** plural subject, present tense; the past participle of *keep* is *kept*.

🟠 Common BEM mistakes

- Forgetting the verb *be*: "The mosque built in 1612" instead of *The mosque was built in 1612*.
- Using the past simple form instead of the past participle: "was *wrote*" instead of *was written*.
- Wrong agreement with the new subject: "The ruins *was* discovered" instead of *were discovered*.
- Keeping the old subject: "The Colosseum was built the Romans" without *by*.

🟡 Quick review

- Passive = be + past participle; the object becomes the subject.
- Present: is / are + PP. Past: was / were + PP.
- Check the agreement: singular → is / was; plural → are / were.
- Add "by + agent" only when the doer is important.
- Learn the irregular past participles: built, made, written, found, taken.